to a more serious regional conflict there than what we are experiencing today. Then, there is the question of China as the world's biggest dam-builder, with rivers flowing from Tibet and Yunnan into other countries downstream—and dams being built without even consulting those countries. There are even plans to divert Tibet's water on a massive scale to China proper.

Tibet, as Maptia, a Western NGO, pointed out,

> is unique in the world as a mass provider of fresh water, via rivers, to China and to a dozen nations downstream. Tibet is the source of major headwaters for the rivers of Asia, and additionally provides key tributaries or feeders for other rivers (such as the Ganges). There is no parallel to this situation anywhere else on the planet. We only have one Tibet: there are no backups, no second chances.[32]

And is the de facto independent island of Taiwan really a part of China, as Beijing claims? Again, China would consider any opinions on these issues other than its own an interference in its internal affairs.

Given this broader perspective of today's geopolitical realities, it makes sense to study further the origin and development of the conflict in the Himalayas as well. China and India remain powerful regional rivals, and the animosity between the two countries began in the Himalayas more than half a century ago.

My research into that border dispute took me to Arunachal Pradesh, Sikkim, and northern West Bengal in India; to Kachin State, Shan State, and Sagaing Division in northern and northeastern Myanmar; China's Yunnan province; Nepal; and Bhutan. I have also spent time at the British Library in London, whose India Office Records are a treasure trove of information. For me, as a journalist, to get to Tibet would have been impossible, but I have studied Chinese documents and maps in detail to find out on what background and historical records Beijing is basing its claims. Numerous people have helped me along the way, but there are just too many to be mentioned, and given the sensitivity of the issue, most of them requested to remain anonymous.

Even so, I would like to thank Dorjee Khandu Thongdok in Rupa, who had to flee when the Chinese attacked his town and later wrote a book about it; two elderly Tibetans I met in Tawang who remembered the Chinese occupation of their town in 1962; a local villager in Walong who told me about events in that area during the war; an elderly Tibetan in